

Von der Leyen's pitch to Paris

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Presented by Connect Europe By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO THERE. I'm Gerardo Fortuna. In today's Playbook: — Club Med's message to António Costa: Berlin's b

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CIAO THERE. I'm Gerardo Fortuna.

In today's Playbook:

- Club Med's message to António Costa: Berlin's budget cuts are a nonstarter.
- Roberta Metsola's bid for a third term gathers cross-party momentum.
- Faces in the crowd: Gabriel Attal, Nicola Procaccini, Timothy Garton Ash, Robert Abela, Fernando Sampedro, Sara Matthieu, Bas Eickhout, Emmanuel Macron, Kira Marie Peter-Hansen, Valérie Hayer, Peter Malinauskas, Nicolae Ciucă, Jean-Claude Juncker and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Sarah and Kathryn unpack Washington's push to get NATO allies to abandon the International Criminal Court.

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****A message from Connect Europe: Meet the leaders steering Europe's digital future. On 1 October, the FT-Connect Europe Forum brings to Brussels former Italian PM Enrico Letta, Nobel laureate Philippe Aghion, top EU officials Roberto Viola and Anthony Whelan, MEPs Adina Vălean and Aura Salla, Telefónica's Marc Murtra, Liberty Global's Mark Fries, MEO's Ana Figueiredo and Nokia's Justin Hotard.****

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DRIVING THE DAY

BACK IN THE LION'S DEN: Is Ursula von der Leyen the right person to make the case for the EU in the midst of a French presidential campaign that could have devastating results for the bloc's future?

The European Commission president will deliver a major speech on the EU's space policy at Emmanuel Macron's space summit at Paris' Grand Palais today, in front of an audience of industry leaders, government officials and military chiefs, Playbook's Nick Vinocur writes.

Her message (we're paraphrasing slightly): It's only thanks to the EU that Europe is able to mount ambitious projects that can compete with other global powers.

Some see her address as timely: "When you consider that some of these CEOs were cozying up to [far-right leader] Jordan Bardella, this is really welcome," said an EU diplomat following the developments, granted anonymity because they're not authorized to speak on the record.

But others doubt that her pitch will land. "It's a red-alert situation. I have never seen France as ill-disposed toward the EU as now," said an EU official. "Brussels and the migrants — these are the two bogeymen." In other words: Von der Leyen's intervention might not have the pro-EU impact Brussels hopes it will.

It's the second time in a month that von der Leyen has addressed an elite audience in France. The Commission president spoke to French business leaders on Aug. 27, highlighting Brussels' work on simplifying EU regulation, building a capital markets union and making it easier for businesses to set up shop.

But the political backdrop is grim for Brussels. Far-right leader Marine Le Pen is leading the polls ahead of next year's presidential election and far-left Euroskeptic Jean-Luc Mélenchon has a realistic shot at joining her in the second round. A Le Pen presidency could have dire consequences for the EU — and there are few strong voices in the presidential race willing to defend the bloc.

The EU official points out that there are two clearly pro-EU candidates running for France's top job: Center-left MEP Raphaël Glucksmann and centrist former Prime Minister Gabriel Attal. "Edouard Philippe [from Macron's camp] is pro-European, but not passionately so," the official said. "It's hard to get people focused on Europe at the moment."

It's still early days in the campaign, with seven months to go, and Brussels will be hoping that voters will pay more attention to the implications of a Le Pen or Mélenchon victory as the election gets closer. But selling the EU's message to French elites is one thing — getting through to ordinary voters is another.

BIG AND BREAKING

EXCLUSIVE — EU ASYLUM CLAIMS CRATER: The number of people applying for asylum in the EU hit a historic low in the past six months, with a 17% decline overall, according to new figures to be released today and seen in advance by Gabriel Gavin.

SCOOP — WASHINGTON VS. THE HAGUE: The United States quietly asked NATO allies to help "systematically dismantle" the International Criminal Court and even quit its founding treaty, Victor Jack reports.

MADE IN ISRAEL, DEFENDING EUROPE: Europe's push for defense-technology sovereignty has a problem: the bloc's security increasingly relies on Israeli defense companies. Antoaneta Roussi reports.

BREXIT REALITY CHECK: Andy Burnham wants a big, new EU-U.K. deal to boost growth. Just don't expect it at this year's summit , Jon Stone reports.

EEAS PLANS FALL FLAT: EU ambassadors didn't mention the prospect of overhauling the EU's diplomatic service when they sat down for breakfast with Kaja Kallas yesterday, two envoys told Playbook, with France backing away from a joint Franco-German paper that proposed stripping back the agency's remit.

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COSTA'S BUDGET TOUR GOES SOUTH

COSTA HEADS SOUTH: After a fraught meeting in Berlin on Wednesday, European Council President António Costa's budget talks will today involve Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez, Portugal's Luís Montenegro and Malta's Robert Abela.

The backdrop: Southern and eastern European countries pushing for a bigger budget are worried that the Irish Council presidency, which is steering the talks, will make major cuts in its next negotiating document (known as a negobox) in October, according to two diplomats from those countries.

Red lines: "Any cuts to agriculture and cohesion would be a no-go for us," said one diplomat. There will be cuts, but they won't be as drastic as those suggested by Germany, said a third diplomat.

Merz wants less: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz on Tuesday renewed calls for Ireland to slash the budget by "several hundreds of billions." During a joint press conference with Costa, Merz said the proposed increase is "simply prohibitive because, at the end, it is the European taxpayer who has to foot the bill."

Club Med's warning: But Spain, Portugal and Malta — who are members of the "friends of cohesion" camp — are expected to warn Costa against budget cuts, arguing they would leave Europe ill-equipped to fund old priorities while investing more in defense and competitiveness. "We cannot do more with less," Spanish Secretary of State for the EU Fernando Sampedro said last week.

Visegrád's special guest: With a few weeks to go until Ireland presents its negobox, the friends of cohesion are making their voice heard. Irish Taoiseach Micheál Martin will join a meeting of the Visegrád Group (the Czech Republic, Hungary, Poland and Slovakia) in Bratislava, to discuss the budget negotiations.

**On Sept. 22, Brussels Playbook takes to the stage to unpack the power plays and policy battles shaping Europe's capital. Hear from the journalists behind POLITICO's indispensable morning briefing as

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20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Next week, EU ministers responsible for cohesion policy will hold talks in Ireland. But what is cohesion policy? It's the EU's attempt to reduce economic and social differences among countries and regions and it has always formed a large part of the long-term budget (almost a third of it, in the current period). The EU splits regions into three groups based on their gross domestic product per person (compared to the EU average): less developed regions (with GDP per inhabitant is less than 75% of the EU average); transition regions (75%–100%); and more developed regions (more than 100%).

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MIDTERM MANEUVERS

METSOLA'S MOMENTUM: Roberta Metsola is picking up support for a history-making third term as European Parliament president, with the right-wing European Conservatives and Reformists broadly backing her and the Socialists and Democrats softening their opposition.

Right turn: ECR Co-Chair Nicola Procaccini told Max Giera that support for Metsola is widely shared within his group. "She is balanced, she is fair and that is exactly what we ask," he said. Metsola's recent public praise for Italian PM Giorgia Meloni's "commonsense solutions" on EU simplification also went down well with the group, he said.

Door left ajar: Meanwhile, S&D President Iratxe García didn't rule out backing Metsola Tuesday. "I'm not going to set any condition from the start," she said — a softer line than the Socialist leaders' pre-summer position insisting the presidency should pass to the center-left at midterm.

Mark your calendars: The European People's Party is preparing to formally select its Parliament presidential candidate at the end of November, according to a draft schedule seen by POLITICO. Metsola is expected to be renominated. Both the EPP and S&D will elect their own leaderships on Oct. 20.

Green rebellion: Elsewhere, Nicolae Ciucă has formally entered the Oct. 7 race to replace Bas Eickhout as Greens co-chair, campaigning for a more confrontational approach toward the EPP. "It is clear we need to be more in the opposition because the [anti-far right] firewall was never respected," he said in his 17-page pitch sent to colleagues. Belgium's Sara Matthieu and Denmark's Kira Marie Peter-Hansen are also widely floated as contenders.

Hayer stays: At Renew, Valérie Hayer looks secure, with no challenger expected, with the group's main factions favoring continuity.

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

CARNEY IN STRASBOURG: Even Europe's Trump-friendly governments are backing Brussels' deeper partnership with Canada, as Ottawa looks for protection from Washington's trade war, I report with Gabriel.

UKRAINE'S BRUTAL LOGIC: Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, whose plane was reportedly almost hit by a drone this week, is gambling that taking the fight deeper into Russia will pressure Vladimir Putin into getting serious about peace talks.

LOVE IN THE TIME OF ELECTIONS: If Attal becomes French president, von der Leyen may have to make the call on whether his life partner, European Commission Executive Vice President Stéphane Séjourné, should quit the Commission .

FEELING THE HEAT? That may be because August was officially the world's joint-hottest month on record .

VUČIĆ ROLLS THE DICE: Serbian President Aleksandar Vučić has dissolved parliament and called a snap October election , in a bid to regain control of an increasingly febrile political scene.

MISTRAL SANS MACRON? What will happen when French global AI darling Mistral's most powerful backer leaves the Élysée? Océane Herrero reports.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals and slight breeze. High of 21C.

WHO'S CHICKEN? The Brussels bubble was clucking with surprise after former Commission President Jean-Claude Juncker posted on X yesterday. The Luxembourgish grandee appeared to log on to the platform for the first time in seven years to post an AI mock-up of himself dressed in a chicken costume, holding a pair of tacos .

Cluckup: Juncker, who maintains an office in the Berlaymont, couldn't be reached for comment. But a spokesperson for the Commission said: "The former President's account on X was indeed hacked. Necessary steps to address the matter were taken." The post was quickly deleted.

ART ATTACK: From today through Sunday, the city becomes one giant gallery for Brussels Art Week, with public institutions, private foundations, auction houses and artist-run spaces opening their doors for four days of exhibitions and events . It's your excuse to wander into buildings you normally walk past.

SOME CRISES ARE BETTER THAN OTHERS: British historian Timothy Garton Ash — chronicler of the 1989 revolutions and longtime thinker on Europe's future — is coming to Brussels on Sept. 24. He'll sit down with journalist Caroline de Gruyter and De Standaard editor Karel Verhoeven at Passa Porta for an event cheerfully titled "A Good Crisis (and How Not to Waste It)." On the menu: Euroskepticism, Europe's place in the new world order and, presumably, how to make the most of ... the current mess.

ALSO STARTING TODAY: The Marni Jazz Festival at Théâtre Marni near Flagey, running through Sept. 19 ... and EAREYE Festival, with three days of dance workshops and performances curated by Swedish choreographer Alma Söderberg.

A NUMBER WORTH SAVING: As today is World Suicide Prevention Day, a reminder that Belgium's Community Help Service runs a confidential, anonymous English-language helpline 24/7. Its trained volunteers receive thousands of calls a year, including from people feeling suicidal. CHS Helpline: 02 616 26 26.

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TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: UAE President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan's state visit could seal a significant deal : a daily Emirates flight connecting Berlin with Dubai.

Paris: Bruno Retailleau has a clear message for his LR supporters: He'll remain a presidential candidate through to the end of the elections .

London: Andy Burnham is under fire from the U.K.'s opposition over defense spending, after saying it can't come at the expense of social security .

Washington: Democrats are countering Donald Trump's midterm convention by injecting their pitch straight into the conservative conversation .

Canberra: South Australian Premier Peter Malinauskas' full-throated support of immigration has made him a political outlier .

AGENDA

- European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen delivers a speech at the International Space Summit in Paris. Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen is also attending.
- European Council President António Costa visits Valletta, where he meets Maltese Prime Minister Robert Abela, before traveling to Madrid for talks with Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez and Lisbon for a meeting with Portuguese Prime Minister Luís Montenegro.
- European Parliament President Roberta Metsola is in Paris, where she participates in the G7 speakers' meeting.
- EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas meets Madagascar President Michael Randrianirina.
- Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič meets Czech Prime Minister Andrej Babiš in Prague.
- Equality Commissioner Hadja Lahbib meets Romanian President Nicușor Dan.
- Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall receives WWF Director-General Kirsten Schuijt.
- Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis meets Latvian Defense Minister Raivis Melnis in Riga.
- Political and Security Committee meets in Brussels at 9:30 a.m.
- The European Central Bank's Governing Council holds its monetary policy meeting in Berlin, followed by a press conference with ECB President Christine Lagarde at 2:45 p.m. Watch live .
- NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte travels to Berlin, where he meets German Foreign Minister Johann Wadephul.
- German Chancellor Friedrich Merz receives UAE President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan in Berlin.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Łukasz Kohut; former MEPs António Marinho e Pinto, Georgi Pirinski, Michèle Alliot-Marie, Monica Frassoni and Renate Sommer; journalist Hadley Gamble; Ole Funke of Germany's Federal Chancellery; Fabio Mauri, founder of DG MEME.

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